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By email: request-1504105-7ddd33b9@whatdotheyknow.com

Date: 9th October 2026

Dear Lexi W

Our Ref: FOI 00539

Email Subject title: Freedom of Information request - Historical FHRS Ratings

I write in response to your correspondence with the Food Standards Agency (FSA) dated 22nd September 2026 in which you submitted a request for information as follows:

My request - as you do not seem to publish historical data (only current), and it would be useful for users to be able to see ratings from before this week (which is when this service started collecting data), I kindly request that, if you have a full archive of historical ratings, or the nearest data you can think of, I would hugely appreciate if you could provide me with this. If the fetching and/or processing of this data would be too cumbersome, please could you provide me with the maximum amount of data you'd be able to process in a reasonable timeframe, most recent first?

Our Response

Current Food Hygiene Rating Scheme (FHRS) data
The latest FHRS open data files are available on our website: https://ratings.food.gov.uk/open-data

2024 – 2026 data
The Food Standards Agency holds a file of all of the data published for each day. If you can specify your requirements e.g. a file containing the published data at the 31st December for each year, we can better assess your request and indicate what can feasibly be supplied.

2012-2023 data - Historical Data via National Archives

Published FHRS data are available for each year from 2012 to 2023 on the National Archives website. Please note that the links provided below point to the final archived version for each respective year, as held by the National Archives. You should note that local authorities introduced FHRS at different points. Where data for earlier years are not available for a local authority this will indicate that the scheme was not yet operated by that local authority.

The following examples are for The London Borough of Barking and Dagenham e.g. https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20230805105732mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml. In the URL you will see the number 501, this represents the local authority ID code. The local authority ID codes can be accessed at https://api1-ratings.food.gov.uk/authorities/xml and if you change the number in the URL to another code you will be able to access other local authority pages.

2023: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20230805105732mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2022: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20221011093354mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2021: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20211201191049mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2020: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20201201132934mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2019: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20191202165217mp_/https://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2018: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20181206192556mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2017: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20180104191124mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2016: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20161220091351mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2015: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20151013154209mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2014: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20141216174707mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2013: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20131220185518mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml
2012: https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/20121205164416mp_/http://ratings.food.gov.uk/OpenDataFiles/FHRS501en-GB.xml

The page https://ratings.food.gov.uk/open-data contains a link to information on using xml files. Further information can be found online e.g. https://www.softwaretestinghelp.com/how-to-open-xml-file/#With_Excel

Before using the data you should be aware of the following:

Column alignment
Changes to the contents of open data may result in the archived datasets displaying in a different column order. You should take this into to account if comparing data for different years.

Important notes on the use of historical data
We would draw the 'about data' section to your attention: https://ratings.food.gov.uk/open-data, particularly:

- Some local authorities use a property-based database, which may result in the re-use of the LocalAuthorityBusinessID numbers and the associated FHRSID for a different business.
- Others use a business-based database, where new IDs are assigned for new businesses.
- Ownership changes may not be reflected in the business name or ID, so historical ratings should be interpreted with caution.

You will wish to consider these issues when attributing a historic rating to an existing business.

Internal Review

If you are not satisfied with our handling of your correspondence, then you may request an internal review.

Please clearly indicate that you wish for a review to be conducted and state the reason(s) for requesting the review.

Please note that it is usual practice to accept a request for an internal review within 40 working days from the date of this response.

Please be aware that the review process will focus upon our handling of your request and whether FSA have complied with the requirements of the Act. The internal review process should not be used to raise concerns about the internal processes of other FSA functions.

To request a review please contact information.governance@food.gov.uk.

Yours sincerely

David Dunford
Information Governance Manager

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